NOVOGENIA · ACADEMY

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS BURNOUT AND STRESS

Answers to typical client questions about genetic stress and burnout predisposition.

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01 · GENETIC BASIS OF STRESS

What is the COMT gene and why is it important?

COMT (catechol-O-methyltransferase) breaks down the neurotransmitter dopamine once an exciting or stressful situation is over, so the brain can return to its baseline. If the gene works poorly, dopamine is broken down much more slowly: the brain stays in an aroused state for longer, and when new stress comes along before it is back at baseline, it can become overloaded. Slower breakdown also has upsides — positive feelings are experienced more intensely and people tend to be more curious, but also more prone to gambling. Studies describe a common variant (Val158Met) with clearly different enzyme activity between the fast and the slow form.

Which three traits does the burnout analysis evaluate?

Performance under stress (how well you perform in stressful situations), emotional resilience (how strongly negative feelings weigh on you) and impulsivity. Each trait is shown on a scale from red through the middle to green: green is favourable, red means a greater risk of burnout.

How many people are genetically especially prone to stress?

About 40% of people have two well-functioning copies of the COMT gene: they tend to perform better under stress, have higher emotional resilience and are less impulsive. About 15% have two defective copies, with exactly the opposite effect — they are the ones who suffer most under stress. The remaining ~45% have one functioning and one defective copy.

02 · PRACTICAL ADVICE

I have two defective copies of the COMT gene — am I doomed to burn out?

No. A less favourable COMT profile increases sensitivity to stress, but it is not destiny. The less favourable the genes, the more important the right lifestyle: meditation, a low-stress way of life, nutrition and exercise. Knowing your predisposition lets you act early, before stress builds up.

All three traits are in the green zone — do I still need to think about burnout?

For you, burnout is not such a big danger — but the risk is not zero: massive, continuous stress can still take its toll over time. Recovery phases and a balanced lifestyle remain important.

What helps everyone, regardless of genotype?

The measures recommended in the report — meditation, a low-stress way of life, a balanced diet and regular exercise — help everyone reduce stress; they simply matter more the less favourable the genetic profile is. Enough sleep, social contact and moderate consumption of caffeine and alcohol are also commonly recommended.

03 · WHAT TO DO WITH THE RESULT

A “red zone” came up in my report. Should I be worried?

It is no reason to panic, but it is a reason to act. A red zone marks an unfavourable genetic predisposition in one specific area — a greater risk of burnout, not a diagnosis. The more of your traits are in the red zone, the more important it is to adapt your lifestyle to avoid stress. Even with results in the middle, a low-stress lifestyle remains important.

Where do I find concrete recommendations for my genotype?

In the burnout report — it contains recommendations on meditation, a low-stress lifestyle, nutrition and exercise, tailored to your genetic stress profile.